

◁ CARVING ICE

The Jostedal icefield in Norway, the largest in Europe, is a remnant of the ice sheet that once carved out the deep valleys of the Norwegian fjords.

◁ NARROW CHANNEL

The Mediterranean Sea is linked to the Atlantic Ocean through the Straits of Gibraltar. The channel is so narrow that Morocco is visible from Spain.

▷ NEW ISLAND

Rising sea levels just 9,000 years ago cut the British Isles off from mainland Europe.

valleys so deep that once the ice melted they were flooded by the sea to form the country's famous fjords.

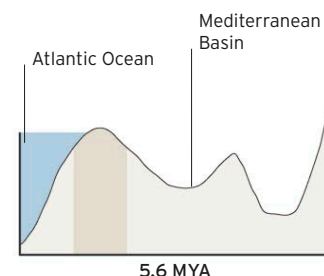
Sea levels fluctuate

During the ice age, Britain was joined to Europe by a long block of limestone—this acted as a dam against rising glacial meltwater. About 450,000 years ago, this natural dam burst, leaving behind the White Cliffs of Dover. Sea levels continued to rise and fall during each glacial and interglacial period, until 9,000–8,000 years ago, when the last ice sheet melted and Britain was cut off from Europe for good.

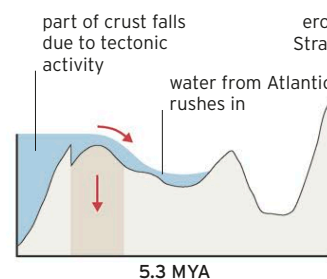
The Mediterranean Sea has also come and gone. It was cut off from the Atlantic Ocean and most of it dried out to a salty desert. Then, the jostling of the African and the Eurasian plates caused the land underneath where the Straits of Gibraltar are now to suddenly fall. This let water flood through as a torrent from the Atlantic Ocean. At first the water pooled into the basin slowly over a period of a few thousand years. However, it is thought that 90 percent of the Mediterranean Sea's water eventually came rushing into the basin in a matter of months to years.

THE FORMATION OF THE MEDITERRANEAN SEA

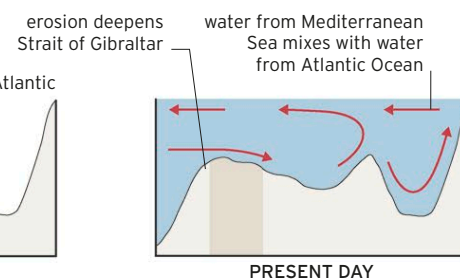
About 5.6 million years ago, the Mediterranean Basin was cut off from the Atlantic Ocean and almost entirely dry. But 300,000 years later, the Straits of Gibraltar fell, and Atlantic waters flooded in and refilled the basin.



5.6 MYA



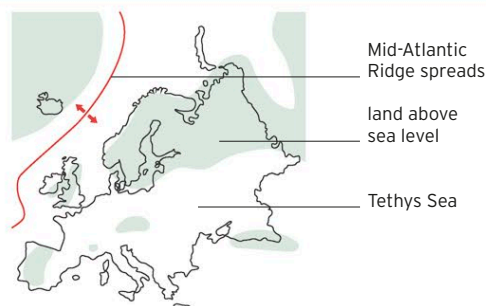
5.3 MYA



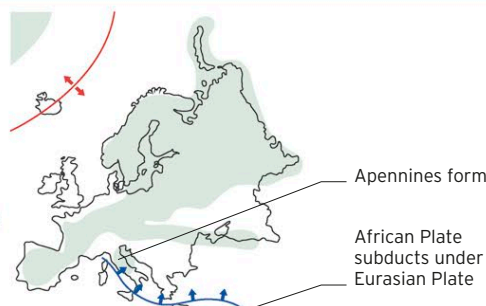
PRESENT DAY

BUILDING THE EUROPEAN CONTINENT

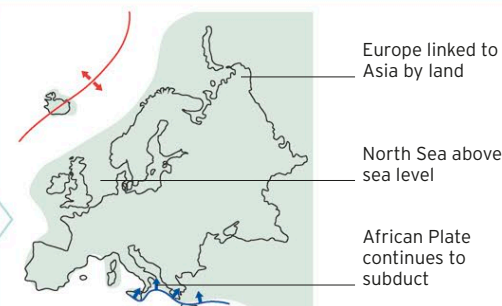
KEY — Convergent boundary — Divergent boundary



94 MILLION YEARS AGO The North Atlantic is spreading to push Europe and North America apart, while southern Europe is entirely inundated by the Tethys Sea between Europe and Africa.



50-40 MILLION YEARS AGO Africa drives north toward Europe. The Tethys Sea is squeezed out, and sediments pile up in southern Europe to form high mountain ranges such as the Apennines.



18,000 YEARS AGO As oceans recede, the Black, Baltic, and North Seas dry out, and Europe has become linked to Asia by land. Europe is at its greatest extent.